AI recruiter sourcing and visibility

Agentic recruiting rewards evidence your profile lacks

Recruiting in 2026 runs as a two-stage machine, and Brent's public surfaces fail both stages. LinkedIn's Hiring Assistant (general availability September 2025, "Hiring Assistant 2" announced September 29, 2026, 20,000+ companies in its first year) parses a recruiter's brief into up to 35 qualifications, retrieves semantically over one billion profile embeddings anchored on current title, seniority and location, then has an LLM mark each qualification met, partially met or missing and quote the evidence back to the recruiter (LinkedIn; LinkedIn Engineering via ZenML). Third-party agents (Juicebox, hireEZ, Metaview, SeekOut) do the same from 30-45+ open-web sources including GitHub and personal sites. The June 2026 LinkedIn export carries a non-standard title ("GTM Systems Architect"), an About with no quotable number, and nothing about the production agent systems of the last 90 days; smoothed.io has a placeholder About page, an empty Journal, stat counters that render as "0" without JavaScript, and no Person schema naming Brent. The post-Labor-Day drop in recruiter queries is partly market (US Sales and RevOps openings fell 6.8% in the month to September 5, head-of-function roles 27%) and partly structural (agentic sourcing is "fewer but better" by design), but the larger lever is that the profile gives an evaluation agent nothing to quote. The recommendation is position C, operator of production AI and agentic GTM systems, expressed in standard filterable titles ("GTM Engineering", "Revenue Operations", "Director"); the July "RevOps/Growth leader at $250K" plan should be dropped because head-of-function RevOps postings are collapsing while the $185-405K money has moved to people who build and govern revenue-touching agents.

Recruiters now retrieve by embedding and screen by quotation

LinkedIn's sourcing stack is no longer a keyword index with filters. A proprietary LLM parses the recruiter's free-text request into title, seniority, location and a qualification list; the MUSE dual-tower model encodes that into one vector for nearest-neighbor retrieval over precomputed profile embeddings; faceted, Boolean, lookalike and personalized retrievers run alongside; an engagement-trained ranker blends them; and an LLM "guard" scores each candidate's fit per qualification and writes the explanation the recruiter reads (ZenML summary). LinkedIn reports that **"title, seniority, and location are the structured attributes most consistently represented in both queries and profiles"**, that the semantic path lifted query coverage to 96% after Boolean returned nothing for roughly half of queries, and that the new stack sources about 4% fewer candidates per seat while sending 4.1% more InMails, "fewer but better" (LinkedIn Engineering Blog). The relevance policy scores "title, seniority, industry, hard skills, and education" and LinkedIn's own example qualifications include "has experience solving ambiguous problems", so the model reads experience narrative, not only skill tags (LinkedIn Talent Solutions).

Hiring Assistant 2 adds persistent memory per recruiter and company, so ranking becomes personalized to past hiring patterns, and it splits two signals: **Fit** (alignment to the role) and **Candidate interest** (platform engagement, Open to Work details, InMail responsiveness) (LinkedIn). The evaluation agent reads the LinkedIn profile, any uploaded resume, ATS records, pre-screen answers and connected-app data, tagging each qualification with its evidence source; sourcing is capped per licence (200 sourced and 3,500 evaluated per month on the base tier) and outreach runs 25 candidates at a time (HeroHunt). Verification is becoming a tie-breaker: 39% of recruiters say they cannot tell whether a candidate is real, and **members with a connected app receive up to 2.9x more recruiter messages** (LinkedIn's own figure, unaudited) (LinkedIn). Connected Apps launched June 18, 2026 with Replit live and GitHub "coming later" (TNW).

The third-party layer converged on the same paradigm: a natural-language brief or example profiles, an agent that runs continuously per role, and thumbs-up/down learning. Juicebox Agents (May 20, 2026) search "GitHub, Google Scholar, Stack Overflow, Medium, and community forums to find people based on their work" (BusinessWire); hireEZ relaunched agent-native on August 18, 2026 over a 45-source index (hireEZ); Metaview's fillmore agents research "each prospective candidate's professional background, career trajectory, and fit against the brief" (Metaview). For a consultant whose best work is in private repos, the personal site is therefore a sourcing surface, not a brochure. One caution: HackerRank's open-sourced screening agent weights open-source and self-projects at 65% of its score and scored the same resume between 66 and 99 across 100 runs, so agentic screeners are both artifact-hungry and noisy (pinggy.io).

The only rigorous candidate-side data point is Fortin's study of 143,258 public profiles (September 30, 2026): **half have an empty About, 58% do not describe their current role**, and for a keyword like "Python" the hit lands only in a former role 53% of the time, a median four years old, so search "reflects who chose to write rather than who holds the skill" (Anara). Hung Lee's reading is that natural-language sourcing will now down-rank profiles weak in "Last company, About section" (Recruiting Brainfood 521). Two LinkedIn help mechanics bite here: Recommended Matches may return "fewer or no" results "for non-standardized job titles" (LinkedIn Help), and the Workplace Types filter only returns candidates who are Open to Work (LinkedIn Help). Nothing in LinkedIn's documentation ties posting activity to search rank; activity feeds the interest score and the feed, where a separate AI-slop classifier now cuts views of generic content by roughly 40% (PureAI).

The September drop is partly market, mostly profile

No public source measures recruiter search or InMail volume by month, so the drop Brent was told about has no baseline. What is measurable points to a real but partial market effect. September payrolls rose only 29,000 against a forecast near 85,000 (CNBC); LinkedIn's hiring rate was down 6.5% year over year in August (LinkedIn Economic Graph); and PredictLeads' tracker shows **US Sales and RevOps openings fell 6.8% (62,598 to 58,319) in the month to September 5 while all US openings rose 5%, with head-of-function roles down 27.1%, Director down 15.2% and VP down 10.2%** (PredictLeads). Tech postings moved the other way: Dice reports tech postings up 9% month over month and 17% year over year in September, with AI/ML postings up 88% and "Agentic AI" and "AI Agents" among skills growing more than 200% (Dice). So the roles the July plan targeted (Head/Director of RevOps or Growth) contracted sharply in exactly the window Brent noticed, while AI-engineering demand rose.

Two structural factors compound this regardless of market. Agentic sourcing concentrates outreach on fewer, higher-ranked profiles by design, and LinkedIn disables bulk InMail for two weeks for any seat whose response rate falls under 13% on 100+ sends (HeroHunt). And recruiters are working inbound floods rather than sourcing: applicants per posting roughly doubled from 46 in 2021 to 95 in 2025 (BambooHR). Being sourced now means ranking near the top of a semantic result set, not matching a keyword.

The profile-side explanation is bigger than the market one, and Brent's assumption that the drop is external deserves pushback. The June export shows current title "GTM Systems Architect", a string LinkedIn's own guidance says will starve Recommended Matches; a practitioner who runs Recruiter daily found "Growth Architect" returned 312 results against 1.2 million for "VP Sales" (Job Search Unlocked). The About contains no number an agent could tag as evidence, and the current-role description names none of the tools, scale or outcomes of the last 90 days, so a brief like "GTM engineer who has shipped production AI agents with evals and approval gates" has no text to embed against (local audit). One mechanic should be checked before blaming the market: LinkedIn removes Open to Work automatically if a member stops answering recruiter InMails and ignores the confirmation email (LinkedIn Help), and the export does not show Open to Work titles at all. If InMails went unanswered over the summer, the feature may be off, which removes him from the Open to Work spotlight, the workplace-type filter and part of the interest score at once.

Choose position C, but spell it in titles that filter

Three positions are on the table. Position A, the July 2026 plan, moves from "GTM Engineer" to "Revenue Operations and Growth leader" for Director/Head seats at ~$250K (repositioning-2026-07). Position B is the current lean back toward GTM engineer. Position C, proposed by the local audit, is operator of production AI and agentic GTM systems. The market evidence favors C and is actively hostile to A as written.

Position A's target is shrinking and its price is wrong. Head-of-function Sales and RevOps postings fell 27% in a single month (PredictLeads); the median RevOps lead's total cash is $150K in 2026, not $250K (Recruitslab); and Upside reports that the "Executive/CoE Lead" ($185-263K, n=60) and "Fractional/Consulting" buckets are **the only two where supply already exceeds visible demand** (Upside). The leadership record behind A is also stale: a seven-person team at Brent's own company in 2010-2015, two SDRs in 2017-2018, solo since 2022 (audit-2026-07-03); an agent asked for "led a RevOps team of five or more" marks that partially met at best. The one bright spot in A's market, "Director of Revenue Operations" postings up 47% in the same month, is a systems-ownership title, which is C's territory.

Position B sorts into the IC pool at the wrong price, which was the July diagnosis and still holds. Steven Moody's hand-checked 491 US postings put the median base at ~$150K, RevOps/Operator (36% of roles) at $150K and Outbound/Growth at $135K, with roles mentioning Clay paying about $17K less, while the Pure SWE archetype medians $219K: the role has split into two bands (Steven Moody). The frontier end is explicit about what it buys: Anthropic's Staff Software Engineer, GTM AI Engineering ($320-405K) wants agents that run GTM motions end to end with approval gates and escalation paths, evaluation frameworks in dev and prod, observability tying agent actions to pipeline, MCP servers, and "using evals and transcript analysis to find and fix real problems" (Anthropic); LangChain posts an "Agent Reliability Engineer, GTM Engineering" at $150-190K; Upside flags "AI Enablement Engineer" as the one archetype with demand roughly twice supply (Upside). Moody's openings-per-candidate ratio is 5.43 for GTM engineers who list AI agents against 2.59 for Clay. Buyers' screening question has moved from "do you know Clay" to "show me a system still running and tell me what happens when a step fails" (HeroHunt).

Position C is the only one the last 90 days actually evidence. The capability inventory shows a production multi-model pipeline with a deterministic rule checker, an LLM judge and one human review, a ~7,000-test suite, 15+ models routed through one transport with a test that fails when the model map drifts, a 21,000-document knowledge library with a claim checker and an eval gate on every refresh, CI-enforced architecture contracts, pre-registered blind model bake-offs, and machine identity with per-step credentials (local audit, section D). That maps almost line for line onto the Anthropic and LangChain postings. The honesty constraint must shape the copy: Brent's own AGENTS.md says he "is not an engineer" and runs agent sessions across tools, and the frontier band lists production Python or TypeScript as a minimum. The truthful framing is "designs, governs and operates production AI systems; the code is written with agent tooling under CI-enforced contracts and tests", a differentiator for Director of GTM Systems, AI Enablement, forward-deployed and player-coach seats and a weakness only for pure staff-SWE reqs. Do not claim the latter.

Expression matters as much as choice. Recruiters' primary string is still `"Clay" AND ("GTM" OR "revenue operations" OR "growth engineering")` searched in headlines and experience (HeroHunt), the semantic layer anchors on standard titles, and the same Recruiter practitioner reports that "Head of" and "Lead" do not reliably register in seniority filters while Director and Vice President do (Job Search Unlocked). "AI GTM Engineer" and "Agentic GTM" are vendor categories, not job titles, and none of the top-25 practitioners use them in a headline; their formula is practice name plus one differentiator (GTME Pulse; Revsure). So C should be written with "GTM Engineering" and "Revenue Operations" in the title fields, "Director" in the Open to Work titles, and the agentic proof in the headline tail, About and bullets where the LLM reads it.

The recommendation differs by audience only in emphasis. For recruiter inbound, the structured fields carry standard titles and the first 100 characters of the headline carry one revenue number and one production signal. For client inbound, the researcher-builder archetype (original data, published method, open artifacts, little service menu) is less crowded than the agency-operator archetype and matches the "evidence not credentials" expectation; the site should lead with the system that is running, not the seven-card service grid (gtm_engineer_market notes). Both audiences read the same About and case studies, so one voice serves both.

LinkedIn: verify the live state, then nine edits in order

A discrepancy blocks any quoting of "current" copy. The PDF dated June 1, 2026 shows headline "GTM Systems Architect | Bespoke Automation & Data Infrastructure", Smoothed title "GTM Systems Architect" and a stale crealytics.com company link, while the July 3 audit recorded the live headline as "GTM Engineer & Systems Architect — I build outbound, lead-gen & CRM infrastructure…" with title "GTM Engineer" and the link fixed (audit-2026-07-03). Either the PDF predates an overhaul that was later reverted or the audit recorded an edit that never saved. Open the live profile and record headline, title, Open to Work settings, pinned skills and Featured before changing anything.

Priority order, each step independent of the next:

- **Fix the Crealytics record first.** Resume says VP of Sales, Jul 2022-Feb 2023; LinkedIn says Enterprise Account Executive, Jul-Dec 2022. An evaluation agent surfaces inconsistencies verbatim, and the uploaded resume is one of its evidence sources. Pick whichever is true and align both.
- **Current title (Smoothed entry):** "Founder & Principal, GTM Engineering". Keep it a conventional string; "Revenue Operations" goes in the headline, skills and Open to Work rather than a blended title. Keep the practice as one company entry with concurrent clients as sub-bullets inside it, since parsers estimate years of experience from dated entries and overlapping roles get double-counted or flagged (GetOnBoard).
- **Headline (draft, ~205 characters):** "Founder, Smoothed | GTM Engineering & Revenue Operations | I design and run production AI agent pipelines for B2B SaaS GTM teams: evals, approval gates, observability | ex-Sales Director, 143% quota, $800K close". Every noun a recruiter types is in the first half; the proof is in the second.
- **Open to Work, recruiters only, every field filled:** Director of GTM Engineering; Director of Revenue Operations; Director, GTM Systems; Head of GTM Engineering; Forward Deployed GTM Engineer; Senior/Staff GTM Engineer (AI). Full-time and contract; Los Angeles and Remote; all three workplace types. Remove bare "GTM Engineer". Then answer every InMail, including declines, or the feature switches itself off.
- **About, first 300 characters:** identity, one revenue number, one production number, target stage; then four quotable paragraphs. Delete "I build growth systems", "two worlds", "funnels, not features" and every "not X, Y" construction; these are catalogued AI tells and carry no evidence (Wikipedia).
- **Smoothed bullets, anonymized, numbers first.** Draft set: (1) Designed and operate a production AI content pipeline for a multi-product B2B SaaS marketing team: an 11-step, 16-day workflow collapsed to five stages; deterministic rule checker, LLM judge and one human review; nothing publishes without a human click; ~7,000 automated tests; 15+ models routed through one transport under a CI-enforced architecture contract. (2) Built a 21,000-document, 3,000-fact company knowledge library (hybrid full-text and vector retrieval) with a claim checker that returns SUPPORTED / CONTRADICTED / NOT IN LIBRARY with the deciding passage; eval-gated nightly refresh; $0.008 median per answered question. (3) LLM cost engineering: attributed spend to pipeline steps (checking, not writing, was two-thirds of the bill), ran blind pre-registered model bake-offs before switching defaults, cut per-page copy cost roughly 4x where quality held. (4) Scoped and sold a customer risk-prediction engagement for a PE-backed CX-assurance SaaS with a Day-30 backtest gate against the client's existing health score. (5) Keep the public receipts: 240,000+ retailers at 72% email discovery (Blingsting), 910 signals at 36% Tier 1 under $0.05 per qualified lead (Thor Data), $81K misdirected spend, 150+ mailboxes with launch cut from ~8 hours to ~3 minutes. Name no client staff; describe both current clients, the solar beta customer and the defense prospect only by category.
- **Add numbers to Skai and Crealytics** (143%/111% to quota, $800K ACV close; $1.45M in five months, +157% reply rate, hired a BDR). Skai is currently the metric-free paragraph on the profile (audit-2026-07-03).
- **Skills:** pin Revenue Operations, Go-to-Market Strategy and Artificial Intelligence (AI) or LLMOps; unpin VS Code. Add, unpinned, the tools that are true and searchable: Python, TypeScript, SQL, Salesforce, HubSpot, Supabase, Smartlead, OpenRouter, Claude, MCP. Do not add Clay unless it is used; the inventory shows none, and it carries a pay discount anyway.

- **Verification and connected apps:** verify identity now; connect GitHub the moment it ships. Add a Featured section with smoothed.io, the Blingsting or Thor Data case study, and one public repo. The smoothops fork (daily LinkedIn jobs scanner with a reconcile-first snapshot ledger, 16-mode skill router on the open agent-skill standard) is a publishable artifact showing exactly the discipline the frontier postings ask for; Navan requires a repo submission and HeroHunt's screen checks public build history before the first call (Pulse #44).

smoothed.io: a brochure with no person attached

The site is technically sound (Astro on Vercel, 25 sitemapped URLs, permissive robots.txt, Organization and Article JSON-LD, four case studies with real numbers) and fails where a sourcing agent looks. The About page body reads "Placeholder content — to be written from design doc." and the Journal says "Articles coming soon."; the four homepage stat counters animate from "0", so anything reading static HTML sees "0 Systems in production, 0 Leads sourced"; Article author is the Organization, and Brent's name appears nowhere in rendered text, so an agent enriching "Brent Bartosch" cannot connect the site to him (local audit, section C). Google says AI features need no special files or schema, only crawlable text with structured data that matches visible content (Google Search Central), and John Mueller has said no AI system uses llms.txt (Search Engine Roundtable). The large-sample evidence on what AI answer engines cite favors clarity and summarization (+33%), E-E-A-T signals (+31%), Q&A format (+25%) and section structure (+23%), with 53% of cited pages under 1,000 words (Semrush; Ahrefs); a vendor study adds that pages with specific numbers, dates and names per paragraph are cited 2.2x more often (Presenc).

The copy problem is voice and specificity, not punctuation. The homepage, systems and case-study pages use "we", the worldview uses "I", and no page says who "we" is. The signature constructions are the ones Wikipedia's field guide catalogs: "Not X. Y." pivots ("We don't sell automation. We build infrastructure."), staccato triads ("Pipeline stalls. Attribution drifts. The right lead sits in the wrong queue."), aphorism closers, and em-dash density in nearly every hero line (Wikipedia). There is no search penalty for this; the penalty is human (recruiters read generic copy as "low effort") and evidentiary (generic text contains fewer qualifications to match) (Hiration). The one document in Brent's files that reads like a specific practitioner is the unpublished one-pager's architecture section ("independent quality gate", "calibrate before you automate", "failure is a designed state"), which should become the site's spine.

Actions, in order:

- **Write the About page as a person.** First person, photo, real name, Los Angeles, what runs today, how engagements work, who it is not for. Add Person and ProfilePage JSON-LD with `sameAs` to LinkedIn and GitHub, and make Brent the Article author on every case study (Google ProfilePage docs).
- **Render the numbers server-side.** Put the counter targets in static HTML and let JavaScript animate them, or drop the animation. Cheapest fix on the list.
- **Replace the hero.** Lead with what is running: "I design and operate production AI systems for B2B GTM teams. Right now: a five-stage content machine with machine QA and one human review, a 21,000-document knowledge library with a claim checker, a 150-mailbox outbound engine." Name the two-role split sophisticated buyers use (pipeline generation versus data foundations) and say which side you take first (Explorium).
- **Add two anonymized case studies** for the content pipeline and the knowledge library, each with a one-paragraph summary at the top, an H2 titled "What happens when a step fails", and per-unit costs ($0.26-0.32 versus $1.18+ per page across models; $0.008 per answered question; 26 marketplace listings read for $0.89). Describe the clients as "a multi-product asset-management SaaS marketing team" and "a PE-backed CX-assurance platform"; no staff names, no contract values. Re-check the existing mid-market SaaS study, whose YC batch year, funding, product category and customer logos make it identifiable.
- **Fill or hide the Journal.** Three pieces exist in Brent's own notes and need only redaction: the architecture pattern language from the one-pager; the eleven pinned failures of running parallel LLM sessions; the method for blind, pre-registered model bake-offs with a committed win rule. Until published, remove /journal from the sitemap.

- **One voice.** Convert every page to first person; replace each pivot, triad and closer with a number, a named tool or a trade-off. Use AI only as an editor on prose Brent drafts, which is LinkedIn's own stance after removing its post-rewriting feature (PureAI).
- **Hygiene:** redirect /sitemap.xml to /sitemap-index.xml; keep robots.txt permissive to AI crawlers; use the unused FAQPage helper on About and case-study pages; treat llms.txt as optional.

Conclusion

The useful reframe is that the profile and the site are no longer read by a recruiter first; they are read by a model that must justify every shortlist line with a quotation, and by sourcing agents that pull the open web into a candidate record. Under that regime the July debate between "leader" and "engineer" was the wrong axis. The question is whether any sentence on either surface survives being quoted as evidence for a qualification like "has operated revenue-touching agents in production with evaluation and approval controls", and today none does, while the private repos contain a few hundred that would. Position C is less a positioning choice than a disclosure decision: publish, in anonymized and specific form, what is already true.

Two implications follow. The structural drop in passive recruiter outreach will not reverse, because agentic sourcing is built to contact fewer people; the profile work buys a place in a smaller top set, not a return to 2024 volumes, so the outbound motion Brent builds for clients should run for his own 20-30 target companies, with the profile and site doing the diligence on the second click. And the "not an engineer" line is an asset if written plainly: a person who designs the controls, enforces them in CI and lets agents write the code is a scarce profile that Director-of-GTM-Systems and AI-Enablement seats are explicitly trying to hire, and no evaluation agent will find it unless the words are on the page.